

COMPREHENSIVE WRITING STYLE GUIDE

Based on 30 Days of Evergreen Email Templates

A Complete Analysis of Voice, Tone, Structure & Style

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This writing style is characterized by direct, conversational authority that speaks peer-to-peer rather than guru-to-student. The voice is unapologetically straightforward, occasionally provocative, and deliberately un-polished to create authenticity.

Core Distinguishing Features:

- **Emphatic repetition** for rhetorical impact ("Wrong, wrong, wrong, wrong")
- **Strategic use of ellipses** to create dramatic pause and control pacing
- **Extreme sentence length variation** from single-word fragments to complex structures
- **Parenthetical humor** and asides that create intimacy with the reader
- **Caps, italics, and bold** used liberally but purposefully for emphasis
- **No-fluff, action-oriented language** that prioritizes clarity over cleverness
- **Pop culture references** and analogies that ground abstract concepts

The writing feels like a knowledgeable friend who's had a few cups of coffee—energetic, opinionated, occasionally profane (though censored), and always moving forward. It never apologizes for being direct and never wastes the reader's time with unnecessary qualification or academic hedging.

Recognition Test: If someone can skim three paragraphs and immediately understand the main point without reading every word, you've nailed this style.

2. VOICE & TONE PROFILE

Primary Voice Characteristics

The Expert Peer (Not the Guru)

This voice establishes authority without condescension. The writer has experience and knowledge but presents as someone still "in the arena" rather than someone who's transcended all challenges.

Example: *"I will be the first to admit that what I did back then was not much more than an accident based on my raw instincts and a willingness to try something different."*

The phrase "I will be the first to admit" creates vulnerability while maintaining credibility—a key characteristic of this voice.

Direct Truth-Teller

The voice doesn't sugarcoat or hedge. It makes bold declarative statements without excessive qualification.

Example: *"Truth: The more email you send, the more money you make, period, full stop."*

Note the structure: "Truth:" followed by an absolute statement, followed by emphatic closure ("period, full stop"). This is signature.

Conversational Authority

The writing sounds like someone talking, not writing. Contractions are standard, sentences can be fragments, and the flow mimics natural speech patterns.

Example: *"Wrong, wrong, wrong, wrong. On so many levels."*

A formal writer would say "This is incorrect in multiple ways." This voice says what it would actually say out loud.

3. STRUCTURAL ELEMENTS

Sentence Structure Patterns

The Power of the Fragment

Incomplete sentences create emphasis and control pacing. They're not grammatical errors—they're deliberate stylistic choices.

Examples:

- *"Wrong, wrong, wrong, wrong. On so many levels."*
- *"Period, full stop."*
- *"Done deal. Easy peasy."*

Usage Rule: Fragments work after a complete thought, never before. They emphasize, conclude, or transition.

The Dramatic Pause (Ellipsis Technique)

Ellipses (...) appear frequently—sometimes multiple times per paragraph—to create conversational pacing and build anticipation.

Usage Rule - Use ellipses to:

- Create anticipation before a reveal
- Signal a shift in thought direction
- Create natural breathing pauses
- Build to a payoff line

Sentence Length Distribution

Ultra-Short (1-5 words): ~15% of sentences

Used for emphasis, conclusions, or dramatic effect.

- *"Wrong."*
- *"Make it happen."*
- *"Look, here's the problem."*

Short (6-15 words): ~40% of sentences

The workhorse of this style. Clear, direct, punchy.

- *"You're burning calories, but so what?"*
- *"The more email you send, the more money you make."*

Critical Pattern: Long sentences are usually followed by short ones for relief and emphasis.

4. LANGUAGE & VOCABULARY

Word Choice Patterns

Action-Verb Dominance

Prefers strong, simple action verbs over weak verb + adverb combinations.

Preferred:

- MAKE it happen (not "cause it to occur")
- CRUSH goals (not "successfully achieve")
- GRAB attention (not "capture interest")

Strong Verbs in This Style:

Make, do, get, take, grab, crush, blast, attack, nail, solve, fix, achieve, build, create, dominate, stop, start

Emphasis Techniques

CAPITALS for Volume

Represents the writer "raising their voice" for emphasis. Used sparingly but deliberately.

Usage Guidelines:

- Maximum 1-2 capitalized words per paragraph
- Reserve for key concepts or critical warnings
- Don't capitalize entire sentences (feels like shouting)

Italics for Tone/Stress

Indicates how the sentence would be spoken aloud, showing which word receives emphasis.

Bold for Key Concepts

Marks important ideas that should stick in the reader's mind.

5. SIGNATURE ELEMENTS

The "Wrong, Wrong, Wrong" Device

Pattern: Repeating "wrong" (or similar word) 3-4 times for emphatic refutation.

Example: *"Wrong, wrong, wrong, wrong. On so many levels."*

Variations:

- "Nope, nope, nope"
- "Stop, stop, stop"

The "Period, Full Stop" Closer

Pattern: Declarative statement + "period" + optional additional closer

Example: *"The more email you send, the more money you make, period, full stop."*

Usage: To signal non-negotiable truth. No further discussion needed.

The "Look," Transition

Pattern: Start paragraph or sentence with "Look," to signal directness

Examples:

- *"Look, I GET IT ..."*
- *"Look, here's the problem."*
- *"Look, never forget that the 'X' in P90X stood for 'EXTREME.'"*

Usage: Signals a shift to straight talk, often before addressing an objection or uncomfortable truth.

The Parenthetical Humor

Pattern: Aside in parentheses, often self-aware or sarcastic

Examples:

- *(Yep, I'm repeating what I just said a few sentences ago. Because it bears repeating!)*
- *(Facepalm. Don't get me started.)*
- *(CAPS mine just to keep this as unsubtle as possible, lol.)*

Usage: Creates intimacy, acknowledges what the writer is doing, adds levity.

6. PRACTICAL APPLICATION GUIDE

Step 1: Start With the Core Message

Before writing anything, distill your message to one simple sentence. This style requires crystal clarity—you can be casual, but never unclear.

Example Process:

- Fuzzy idea: "I want to tell people about my program"
- Core message: "Stop counting calories and start eating real food"
- Style application: "Stop counting calories. Period. When you follow my system, you will actually reduce your calories SPONTANEOUSLY ... without even thinking about it."

Do's Checklist

- Use "you" and "I" extensively
- Write like you talk (contractions, fragments, casual language)
- Vary sentence length dramatically
- Break paragraphs frequently (white space is your friend)
- Ask rhetorical questions
- Use concrete examples over abstract concepts
- Add emphasis (caps, italics, bold) sparingly but deliberately
- Include personality (humor, asides, opinions)
- Be direct—say what you mean

Don'ts Checklist

- Don't hedge ("kind of," "sort of," "maybe," "perhaps")
- Don't use academic or overly formal language
- Don't write long, unbroken blocks of text
- Don't qualify everything ("in my opinion," "it seems like")
- Don't be neutral—this voice has opinions
- Don't over-explain—respect reader intelligence
- Don't use passive voice unless intentional
- Don't forget the call-to-action

7. EXAMPLE TRANSFORMATIONS

Before & After: Formal → This Style

BEFORE (Formal Academic):

"It is important to note that the process of learning guitar requires consistent practice and dedication. Research has shown that individuals who maintain a regular practice schedule demonstrate significantly improved proficiency over those who practice sporadically."

AFTER (This Style):

"Here's what nobody tells you about learning guitar: Forget talent. Guitar players are not born ... they are MADE. You know what separates the players who get good from the ones who quit? Consistency. Not some mystical 'gift.' Not perfect pitch. Just showing up regularly and doing the work."

What Changed:

- Academic distance → Direct personal connection
- Passive constructions → Active voice
- Long complex sentences → Varied length with fragments
- No personality → Parenthetical asides, direct address
- No emphasis → Strategic caps and italics
- Formal vocabulary → Conversational language

FINAL NOTES: Maintaining Authenticity

This style works because it feels real. It's not perfectly polished. It includes:

- Occasional repetition
- Sentence fragments
- Casual asides
- Direct opinions
- Emotional language
- Personal examples

The #1 Rule: Write first as if you're explaining something to a smart friend over coffee. Then edit for clarity and emphasis—but don't edit out the personality.

The #2 Rule: Read everything aloud. If it sounds stiff or formal when spoken, rewrite it.

The #3 Rule: When in doubt, choose the simpler, more direct way of saying something. This style trusts the reader's intelligence and respects their time.

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This style guide is a living document.

As you practice, you'll develop your own variations while maintaining the core elements that make this voice distinctive and effective.